

Bessent-He AI "notification mechanism" leaves much to be desired

送信者: EG US Daily 受信日時: 2026-09-24 00:45

【メール原文】

Bessent-He "notification mechanism" is minimal step on AI coordination . The AI "notification mechanism" proposed between Treasury Secretary Scott Bes|||||||

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Bessent-He "notification mechanism" is minimal step on AI coordination. The AI "notification mechanism" proposed between Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and his Chinese counterpart He Lifeng would be, if it moves forward, only a very minimal step towards substantive US-China collaboration on AI risks.

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The proposed mechanism doesn't appear to be much more than Bessent and He having concrete plans to call each other if there is a major AI-related national security threat in the future; it would not reportedly involve professional or expert staff, making it solely a political—not a technical—vector. The relatively limited substance of the proposal reflects the structural barriers toward getting US-China AI cooperation off the ground in an environment still characterized by competition between the countries on the technology.

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Bessent is also reportedly a frontrunner to fill the vacant position of "AI czar," previously held by David Sacks, who now serves in an informal but still highly influential advisory role. The role, which Bessent would likely hold alongside his day job at Treasury, would likely be a convening function with some coordination and policymaking authority.

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Elevating Bessent on AI policy might suggest more emphasis from the administration on cyber risks, particularly pertaining to the financial sector, on which Bessent has been vocal in the past. That doesn't mean that cyber voices as such would become more influential, but it would suggest that concerns from the financial sector about cyber risks would have a more direct vector to being heard in the White House. Bessent would also likely seek to prioritize the adoption of industry-wide standards, such as on agentic settlement.

China's omission is most notable element of Trump's UNGA speech. President Donald Trump addressed the United Nations General Assembly in New York City yesterday; his remarks were a formulaic rehashing of much of his Truth Social rhetoric, offering minimal direction on the shape of US policy moving forward.

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On Iran, President Trump reiterated threats of "annihilation," which follow an ongoing pattern of oscillation between extreme threats of destruction and strong pushes for peace. US-Iran talks on the sidelines of UNGA were reportedly minimal, reinforcing our view that a negotiated peace agreement is unlikely in the near-term (15% odds, see Standoff now likely to run through 2026 as Hormuz traffic increases , 1 September 2026).

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Trump was scattershot on other subjects: claiming a victory in securing "permanent control" over security "and all other needs" in Greenland, predicting an imminent fall of the Cuban government, and criticizing Mexico for being run by drug cartels while also lauding warm relations with its government. Trump is ultimately most concerned with racking up as many foreign policy wins as he can, and described each region in terms of what he had accomplished.

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Notably, Trump steered clear of mentioning China except to share that the US was "winning" the race in AI. Trump is, at least partially, setting the table for President Xi Jinping's visit to Washington this week where export controls, tariff reductions, and AI safety are on the docket (see: Summit "success" through incremental deliverables that prevent deterioration of ties , 20 September 2026).

Mutual AI restraint requires antitrust waiver that won't be granted. Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei's plan for AI companies to coordinate on safety standards would require an antitrust waiver to shield them from federal scrutiny. There is little appetite for one outside of AI companies themselves.

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Elected officials across the political spectrum, and with varying positions on the danger of continued AI development, all agree that collaboration on safety standards would constitute illegal collusion under antitrust law; granting a waiver would either unacceptably slow development, be redundant when added to existing law, or do too much to protect AI labs from liability, depending on who you ask (see chart).

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Any federal action on AI will be framed as national security rather than safety. The 2027 NDAA has a narrow antitrust carve-out that lets labs coordinate responses against national security threats; even this measure, however, is uncertain to survive into the final version of this legislation.

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While mutual restraint among AI companies would address both the companies' and public's concerns about safety, without antitrust protections it leaves the labs unacceptably exposed to litigation. No lab is going to decide to slow down on its own, though, meaning that the sector will continue to push forward.

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For more, please see Mutual AI restraint requires antitrust waiver no one supports , 22 September 2026.

Quote of the Day

“There’s an argument that some make that this is a very unique political window and, oftentimes in politics, you do only get one shot. And you don’t — and just in life in general — life doesn’t wait for you to be ready for things. Sometimes life just makes things ready for you.” – Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez (D-NY), de facto leader of the progressive left, speaking to the New York Times on whether she will run for president in 2028. Ocasio-Cortez is clearly grappling with the question of whether to run or to seek a Senate seat, and the best case for her bid—one which her supporters will make over the next few months as part of a “draft AOC” movement—is that the combination of the rise of the progressive left in the party and the wide-open nature of the likely 2028 field make this perhaps the ideal time to mount a bid.

On the Radar

18-28 September: High-Level Week at UN General Assembly

24 September: Trump-Xi summit

2 October: Last day Senate is in session before midterms

3 November: National midterm elections

10 November: US-China tariff truce expires

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

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